

designed drives one on top of the other. As we noted earlier, this is useful when you connect several such drives in a daisy-chain.

Size-wise, the LaCie Design by F. A. Porsche has the smallest dimensions, followed by the Freecom. The Seagate drives are larger. The LaCie is also the lightest, weighing just 900 grams; the Seagate Pushbutton Backup 200 and 400 GB drives are heavier at 1.176 kg.

The Freecom drive as well as all the Seagates come with sturdy plastic stands to keep them in an upright position so as to save on desktop space.

Performance: Synthetic Tests

HD Tach RW

The CPU utilisation of the Seagate Pushbutton Backup 200 and 400 GB drives was the lowest at 7 per cent—just marginally less than the 8 per cent of the Freecom and LaCie and the 9 per cent of the Seagate Pushbutton Backup 160 GB drive. A figure of 8 or 9 per cent is perfectly fine. The case was similar with random access speeds, where the drives performed almost on par.

In the Average Read and Average Write tests, the Freecom FHD-3 and the LaCie scored high—with almost equal scores.

SiSoft Sandra 2007 Engineer

As was the case in HD Tach, the Freecom and the LaCie were the top scorers, with the Freecom scoring 30 and the LaCie scoring 29 MBps as the drive index. The other drives topped out at 25 MBps.

In the Random Read speed test, the LaCie scored 25 MBps, falling short of the 28 MBps scored by the Freecom FHD-3. The access time of the Freecom was the lowest at 6 ms, while at 22 ms, the Seagate Pushbutton Backup 160 GB was the slowest.

Performance: Real-World Tests

In the 1 GB assorted data transfer to the external drive, which tests the write performance, the Freecom was the slowest; there wasn't much variance in the scores of the others. Greater variance was seen when data was read from the drive. Here the LaCie and the Freecom completed the job in 43 seconds, whereas the older Seagate 160 GB took 55 seconds for the same job.

In the sequential 1 GB data transfer test, too, there wasn't a large degree of variation between the drives, with the fastest and the slowest drives differing by a maximum of 7 seconds.

Copying files between partitions on the same drive pushes the drive mechanics to the limits. In the assorted files copy, the LaCie, at 88 seconds, was the fastest, while the Seagate 160 GB was the slowest at 113 seconds. In the sequential file transfer, the Seagate 200 and

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Seagate
Pushbutton Backup 200 GB

400 GB performed better than the others, taking 87 and 88 seconds respectively. The Seagate 160 GB took much longer: 108 seconds.

Finally, we transferred the assorted files simultaneously from and to the drive. Once again, the Seagate 200 and 400 GB drives performed well, taking 101 seconds. The Seagate 160 GB and the Freecom FHD-3 were slower, taking 118 and 114 seconds respectively. From this, we can see that while synchronising or backing up data, the Seagate 200 and 400 GB drives will definitely do a better job.

Our Conclusion

Once again, the cost factor was considered at the end to decide the winners. We found that the cost per MB of three of the drives was 4 paise; the Freecom FHD-3, which costs Rs 28,000, is very expensive at 7 paise per MB. The high cost can be attributed to the expensive Acronis True Image software, which is an excellent data backup software; it can be a lifesaver if your system crashes.

The Seagate Pushbutton Backup 160 GB has the same good features as the other Seagate drives such as the dual FireWire ports, a good data backup software, and a button to automate the backup process—along with average, but not bad, performance. Priced at a rock-bottom Rs 6,500, this drive wins the Digit



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